NDCP-2018 focuses on the second objective and by and large ignores the first one. Its vision statement aims to ‘fulfil the information and communication needs of citizens and enterprises through the establishment of ubiquitous, resilient, secure, accessible and affordable Digital Communication Infrastructure and Services and, in the process, support India’s transition to a digital empowered economy and society’. It sets its goals in terms of providing digital infrastructure services to people: universal broadband connectivity at 50 Mbps to every citizen; 1 Gbps connectivity to all gram panchayats; 100 Mbps broadband on demand to all key development institutions; fixed-line broadband access to 50 per cent of households; unique mobile subscriber density of fifty-five by 2020 and sixty-five by 2022; deployment of public Wi-Fi hotspots; and connectivity to all uncovered areas. There is no mention of enabling businesses to get digital infrastructure services to transform the production of goods and services.

NDCP-2018 talks about establishing a National Broadband Mission, but securing universal broadband access through four different nets: BharatNet, GramNet, NagarNet and JanWiFi. It also talks about the Fibre First Initiative to take fibre to the home and key development institutions in Tier 1, 2 and 3 towns and rural clusters. Grudgingly, it mentions ‘every enterprise’ as well.

NDCP-2018 is welfare-oriented, not business-oriented. Global enterprises that have developed and own their digital technologies are making an enormous amount of money. Indian corporates do not have these digital technologies. The policy should have focused on getting these technology majors to invest in India to create the most advanced and functional digital infrastructure in the country. The goal of attracting $100 billion of foreign investment is mentioned. Merely making such a general statement will not bring FDI. We need to create customized solutions, like the PLI initiative, to get electronics manufactured in India. In fact, if we